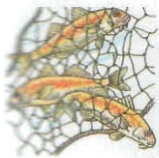


FISHING INDUSTRY



LONG BEFORE FARMING BEGAN, people fed themselves by hunting fish and land animals. Today, the fishing industry continues this hunting tradition. Fishing vessels go to sea from every country with a coastline.

Small boats, such as the stern trawler, have few crew members, and fish within a day's sailing of their home port. The biggest fishing ships can stay at sea for months, and freeze their catch on board.

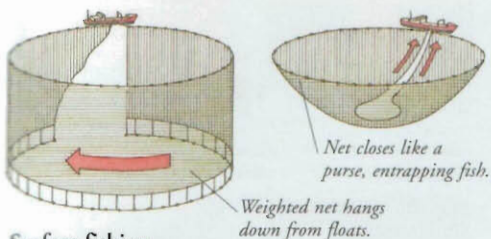
Sea fishing

Most sea fish live within 50 m (165 ft) of the surface. They are concentrated in the shallow waters around the coasts of continents. In the past, the supply of sea fish appeared limitless. However, intensive fishing in areas that were once rich in fish, such as the Grand Banks of North America, has driven cod and other popular species to the edge of extinction.

Deep-water fishing

To catch demersal fish (those that live near the ocean floor), fishing boats sink bag-shaped nets in the water. The fish are trapped by towing the net along the bottom (trawling) or drawing the neck of the net closed (seine fishing). The boat then hauls in the net to land the catch.

Seine fishing



Surface fishing

Many species of pelagic fish (those that live near the surface) swim together in large groups called shoals, and it is these shoals that fishing boats seek. They catch them by enclosing the shoal in a purse seine net, which is like a circular curtain. Pulling a line closes the bottom of the net, preventing the fish from escaping.

Ocean mammals

The oceans are also home to mammals. Fishing for whales, the world's largest mammals, has now almost ceased because their numbers fell so low. The fur of the seal makes it a target for hunters, and although few fishing vessels catch dolphins deliberately, many dolphins die because they become entangled in abandoned nets.

In the past, whaling crews made beautiful carvings out of the bones and teeth of sea mammals.



Fishing with lines

To catch valuable tuna, fishing boats trail a line as long as 180 km (112 miles, 97 nautical miles). Branching off this line are 200 smaller lines, each ending in a baited hook. This arrangement is known as a drifting longline.



Traps

Bait lures lobsters into this basket-like "pot", which rests on the seabed in shallow water. Its funnel-shaped entrance makes escape impossible. Fish traps take many different forms: the Mediterranean tuna trap, for example, is like a maze of net corridors anchored to the seabed. There are even special aerial traps for catching flying fish.

Freshwater fishing

Only 5 per cent of the world's fish catch comes from freshwater sources, such as rivers and lakes. However, in non-industrialized nations freshwater fishing with lines and nets is a vital industry, especially on great lakes such as those in East Africa's Rift Valley. In industrialized nations, anglers have to pay to fish on the few remaining stretches of unpolluted water.



Fish farming

Just as farming produces meat more efficiently than hunting, farming fish is more efficient than catching them. Fish farms breed fish carefully to give good-quality stock, and protect the young fish in ponds or enclosures from predators. Carp and trout are the main freshwater farm fish.

Angling

Fishing for sport is known as angling, and is as ancient as fishing for food. Anglers fix a hook to a thin line and then cast it into the water using a long, flexible rod. To lure fish, anglers bait the hook with worms or insects. They may also use a "fly", which is a hook disguised as an insect.

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